The Desert Oracle

For three weeks I traversed this furnace of dust convinced that celestial mathematics alone could resolve our quest. I believed the recovered Astrolabe was self-sufficient-that every secret of the Order lay charted in distant light. I was arrogant. The heavens may trace the celestial dial, but the earth demands a living keeper.



Past the red pillars, following a dry salt riverbed, I caught the scent of burning cedar. Hidden beneath a massive sandstone overhang was his base: a stone hermitage sheltered by coarse canvas, flanked by stone cairns and alignment stakes driven into the dust.

From the ridge above, I watched him for hours. He ignored the constellations, instead pouring red sand through his palms and arranging black river stones upon a weathered table. When he turned, his face was entirely lost within his cowl, yet he looked straight toward my perch. He knew I was there before my boots touched the stone.

My judgment of this hermit is unequivocal: he is unsettling and secretive, yet utterly indispensable. He guards the terrestrial coordinates lost to our Order - the buried anchor required to unlock the Astrolabe.

I cannot approach him; my tools belong to the stars. But you, Silvia, who unraveled the eight seals of this journal, possess eyes that see both sky and dust. Seek his outpost when shadows lengthen. The Desert Path is yours.

